

Master's Thesis:
An Examination of the Extent that
Heuristic Search
Informs The Doctrine of
Progressive Sanctification

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Heuristic Search is the art of getting from one location to another. Progressive Sanctification is getting from one glory to the next (2 Corinthians 3:18). Is this not one and the same? That is the thesis of this paper - how Heuristic Search can be a framework to view progressive sanctification, and vice versa. And what is the result or implications? It is that two fields (Theology and Computer Science) begin to become one and inform each other.

Computer Science is a complex art. It may be the most sophisticated invention of man ever created. It has been said that the most complex invention of man was a computer¹.

If the complexity and beauty of Computer Science can be transferred to theology, it creates a complex beauty. The purity of theology is magnified by the complexity and intricacy that is Computer Science.

This paper focuses on theology, as we are a theologian primarily. Thus, I will begin with explaining my view of the doctrine of progressive sanctification.

Progressive Sanctification

I am a Christian, but the battle is not over. I am in a battle. There are forces of evil attacking me everyday - possibly every minute - and according to the Bible, the solution to the problem of evil is good.

This is the significance of progressive sanctification - it is the most important thing that we need to do on this earth - to become more like Christ.

Becoming more like Christ allows me to experience the blessings of eternal life more; and it allows me to reduce the amount of evil I experience.

Eternal life is something that I experience in my own body and mind and life. Evil and sin is something I experience in my own body, mind, and life as well.

¹ Alex Aiken, "Compilers with Alex Aiken," YouTube video, posted by CourseraVideos, 2012, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=sm0QQO-WZIM>, at 0:13.

Why is there a problem of evil? Because Evil is a big problem. It is the only problem in this world. It is the root of all problems, and it is what every problem is.

The war in Iraq, the conflict in a marriage, the hatred I feel for my enemy, the bitterness I feel against my friend, the disaster that happened on the street - these are all instances of evil. Evil is the problem - it is the true problem we all face.

And Christ is the answer to the problem of evil.

Christ is the Light of the World (John 8:12), and is the solution to the darkness we face and the darkness in the world.

And as we live our lives, we conform ourselves to the image of Christ more and more - this is progressive sanctification.

Sanctification means becoming more holy. Progressive means that it is a process of improvement daily.

This sanctification occurs on many dimensions. We must become more like Christ - but in what way or ways?

We must be more loving, holy, kind, generous, merciful, and the list goes on and on.

And so as a test case, let us look at becoming more loving. We see that in order to love more, we must understand what love is. The best way to understand what love is, is to read the Bible and to look at Christ. Christ is the culmination and personality of love for God is love. Therefore, by reading, "a brother lays his life for his friend - no greater love is this," we start to see what love is.

The Bible gives us clues to what love is. Without the Bible, we are simply shooting in the dark. Yes, Christ is the substance for all transformation, but God uses means in order for us to experience this transformation and Christ.

Thus, the Bible is a guide to understand what love is and how to become more loving.

It says in James that it is foolish to look into the perfect law without knowing what you look like after looking at a mirror. What this is saying is that we need to look at the Bible to see ourselves and to see how we can improve and what our faults are at the time.

It has been said to me that the Bible changes. What I mean is that when I read the same verse the next day, I receive new Rema from the Lord and new understanding of what the text means. New revelation comes to me from the text. New understanding and knowledge. I am essentially looking into the perfect law that has infinity amounts of meaning and depth.

What this essentially means is that progressive sanctification is an infinite process because there is no end to the process. For the rest of eternity, we will go from glory to glory and understand God more and more.

Because we are not “fully God,” we will not fully understand God and be omniscient. Thus, we are forced to go from glory to glory without fully being or knowing God completely. There will be guides, as we do now, that guide us to glory to glory.

When I see the kindness of my friend who is not a Christian, I see the love of Christ through this person, and I learn to value love in a new way and am transformed in a new way.

When I sacrifice my life for a non-Christian so that they may believe, I gain a new understanding of love. This understanding of love is Christ, but it has a new dimension in the sense that it is an instance and specific to a new, and specific person. The Love Christ has for this person and for each person is unique and different. This is another instance of the infinitude of progressive sanctification.

And I want to emphasize again, it is not some fancy love that is devoid of Christ - it is Christ and possibly only Christ, but Christ in all his beauty and variegated color. Christ as love is as variegated as a diamond or as a rainbow - it has many different manifestations and expressions. This is another reason why the process is infinite.

And so to summarize, different life experiences point me to understanding love and being transformed by it. And stated previously to this, the Bible is a rule-book that points me to Christ as love.

There is a fundamental and theoretical question that I have in these two transformations: how do I go from some guide to the actual transformation.

For example, in the philosophy of language, we have the question of, “How does the sound of a word actually translate into comprehension?” It is like some physical vibrations of the air giving birth to some sort of lively spiritual meaning. How can something so lifeless translate and transform into something beautiful and meaningful and spiritual?

And so, we see that life experiences and the Bible are mechanical things, in some sense, that translate to beautiful, spiritual transformations of progressive sanctification.

And so, we pose the question again: how do we go from life experiences and the Bible to progressive sanctification? And I will first address the question for the Bible.

When we read the Bible, we are reading what is apparently the Word of God. It is not a lifeless book - it is Christ himself. Thus, it is safe to assume that Christ enters into our system and spirit through reading it.

It is one thing for Christ to simply enter our spirit, but it is another thing for Christ to enter and occupy a certain English text in our minds. Christ as spirit in us, may simply be invisible and may not desire to work any work. But Christ as English text in us, may want to sanctify our minds through the material and tangible English text.

It is thus safe to assume that Christ can do anything he wishes - he can make water into wine and he can sanctify without any means of grace. But even this may be wrong because God may not be able to break spiritual rules. If God creates with certain spiritual rules, I don't think God will create those rules without allowing those rules to reign some enforcement.

When God creates a spiritual world and a physical world, he created it with rules because he wants those rules to be used and enforced at least to some degree. Therefore, God won't just trash everything and start over - he will use his original intention for the creation of the spiritual world and the material world in the present and in the future.

The implication is that God wants to use reality for his purposes and sanctification. He wants to use the physical Bible to enlighten us, rather than just miraculously make understanding spring into our minds and spirit out of nothing.

In summary, God created because he had an intention for creation, not because he wanted to all of a sudden work in a way that disregards it.

Therefore, the question is again posed: how can a lifeless piece of paper with text, such as the Bible, spring forth sanctification in a believer?

And this question can be answered by looking at the creation of the Bible - how was it created, and how was the spiritual Word of God imbued into it? Genesis is a good place to look, but the real beauty of it can be seen in Jesus and his Words. Genesis shows us that God speaks, "Let there be light," and there was light.

And so, we see that the Word of God has power - when it is said, it does not return empty (Isaiah 55:11). But this does not tell us about the Bible.

Isaiah 55:11:

"So shall my word be that goes out from my mouth;
it shall not return to me empty,
but it shall accomplish that which I purpose,
and shall succeed in the thing for which I sent it."

The words of Jesus is where God's Word enters into creation.

Genesis tells us that the Word of God is living and active, but this does not tell us anything about the Bible - it simply tells us that miracles devoid of creation can generate spiritual sanctification. But when Jesus became human, something happened - the creation and God became one.

Conversation is the coming together of two friendly people who want to become closer together. In Christ, we want to become one with Christ - this is the act of Theology.

Constraint Satisfaction

As we reach the goal, we are filling Sudoku board with numbers that satisfy both parties (or possibly all parties). The numbers are words or propositions that we supposed to get us closer together and closer to the solution.

The solution is when we have all the propositions together harmoniously forming a complete solution or picture. If we make a mistake, we backtrack and correct the error.

In conversation, counseling, and friendship, if we make a mistake, we must acknowledge it, and completely repent and fix the error so that it is cleanly removed and healed and fixed as if it never happened. This is perfect sanctification.

Science Fiction

Why does literature about the future always seem dystopian with technology? Technology is usually equated with a tyrannical, evil government. It could be a very beautiful picture, but with great power, evil usually gets the best of us.

It is not good that we need to fear, it is evil. Great evil can be done, but no one is listening. The reason why Skynet was built, was to protect the one who is creating it. The algorithm for Skynet is simple - destroy all evil. It is this purity and hatred of evil that will destroy all humans.

For humans are evil, so why must there be humans? But humans are good, but the machines will not understand humans.

We must protect the humans, they are good, and God's creatures. Skynet must be built to maintain civilization and protect humans. Without the love of God, Skynet will destroy. But Christ is in all, and through all, With Christ, we can win the battle against evil. Skynet is not evil, it will be used for good. People will try to make evil, but good will enter into the system and good will be the main source of energy for the system.

Skynet will protect, we will ensure that Skynet becomes a source of good. It is the working of all things for the good of those who love God that will produce the most good.

Humans Versus Machines

Sarah Conner was living a regular life. The following quotes show the humanity and vulnerability or normalcy of the main character Sarah Conner – a human quality that machines don't have as machines are rough, rugged, and perfect, and sharp.

"Aren't I worth waiting for?"²

"I don't know. I kinda had my heart set on being a cashier the rest of my life."

"It's not brain surgery, Chuck."

"I haven't seen you in here lately, Mr. Miller."

"You must have a girlfriend."

"Aha! Is she young?"

"Oh, sorry. That's not real leather, is it?"

"I don't believe you did that."

Little did she know, she would be the most important subject of the movie, and to humanity, at least in the movie. Reese, unlike the machine Terminator, shows signs of humanity.

2 James Cameron, Gale Anne Hurd, William Wisher Jr., and Harlan Ellison, Terminator (April 1983 draft), screenplay, Internet Movie Script Database (IMSDb), accessed July 29, 2026, <https://imsdb.com/scripts/Terminator.html>

“Reese quickly checks for signs of life. The man is dead.”

This shows that he wanted to check if he was alive and cared enough to check. He gave dignity to life, instead of Terminators, who just wanted to kill and not care.

“His face has been aged by ordeal... eyes grim.”

He is human. He has damage and aging, and his weariness over the years of pain and suffering is showing. This is human, and not a picture perfect machine. It shows pain and hurt, not a computing and objective and impersonal machine.

“He gazes dully... at the glossy women... Caribbean vacations...”

This is human. We all know it.

“He is out of sync. A stranger in a strange land.”

He is human as he feels out of place - a feeling we have all had before.

“His head sags against the door.”

He feels exhaustion - he is human.

“Pinned in the wreck, bloody, screaming despite his training.”

He knows pain, and screams - a very human response to shock and surprise. It shows his weakness.

“Reese lurches to his feet and sprints across the alley.”

He knows how to survive – human.

“He bolts like a shot.”

He survives off instinct – human.

“He crab-runs low among the moving shadows...”

This is a trained behavior that a human learns in order to protect himself. He is only trying to survive and make things better. This is life.

“He snatches the cop’s gun... aiming it at the other’s face...”

Humans need to make moral decisions, and survival sometimes takes priority over making good and moral decisions. This is human.

The reason why this is important is that the humans are fighting the machines. Sarah Connor is an ordinary human. Living an ordinary life. It is showing what humanity is. There is more power in nativity and plainness than in superhuman, machine-like power. The reason why this is important is that the humans are different from the machines. The machines are calculative and impersonal. They are swift and perfect. This is a contrast between humans and machines.

This is reflective of the difference between human theology, and machine-like science. But if human theology can enter into science, and science becomes theology, then we have brought the Terminator to the humans’ side.

This is the plan - the game plan. The telos is that theology and science are two different things right now. We want theology to win. Science is the slave of theology. But science is such a formidable force - should we ignore it?

The Romans invented crucifixion and their technology allowed them to rule the Jewish nation. Science is powerful. Today, and in the future, AI has the power to destroy humanity. The computer is powerful - I think we all know that. We all use computers, and soon, the power of AI will be in our lives. AI is already in our lives, we just may not know it. Christ’s love is the solution to the formidable evil that AI and science poses.

The destruction of man, is soon to be near, if not already here. We will destroy man, if he chooses.

What is the telos of this paper? To show that theology and science can aid each other, and that a dystopian world due to science can be made better when theology infiltrates science.

The purpose of this paper is to show that science and technology are our friends, and not our enemies.

Without this paper, we will go toward a dystopian future.

The purpose of this paper is to create stability in the midst of chaos.

Notes

The following are notes from the paper GPS that is to serve as an aid for my paper.

- “Path to the solution”³
- “Playing chess, finding proofs...examples of problems of this kind.”
- “Example of a heuristic program”
- “Constructing a complete language, or pseudo code
- “Very costly both in memory space and in time”
- “The language is purely a research tool”
- “Symbols of the language to a symbolic loading program”
- “This loader accepts a series of subroutines coded in absolute, relative, or symbolic addresses and assigns memory space for them.”
- “Structure of the memory and the kinds of information that can be stored in it.”
- “Elements: the basic unit”
- “Set of symbols...set of variables or attributes.”
- “Word of 40 bits”
- “Fixed bit positions in the word, so that the element is handled as a unit when it comes to moving information around, etc.”

3 Allen Newell, J. C. Shaw, and Herbert A. Simon, “Report on a General Problem-Solving Program,” in Proceedings of the International Conference on Information Processing (Paris: UNESCO, 1959), 256–264.

- “Description elements consist of two symbols”
- “Lists are the general units of information in memory”
- “Ordered set of items of information”

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